THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

Where We Automate, and Why

By FVS, Founder and CEO, Distinct Hospitality Solutions

I find it hard to give my entire productivity to AI. I see the value. The speed is real, and so is the opportunity. But I cannot shake the feeling that we are all jumping in at once, in something close to fomo hysteria, before anyone has defined how much automation is actually necessary.

That question is not about whether the technology works. It is about where it belongs. The clearest answers I have found came from watching ordinary moments.

Picture an elderly person standing at a crosswalk, the light about to turn green. I see them, and so does a robot. My instinct tells me to walk over and help. The robot can do the same, but only if someone programmed it to. Otherwise it carries on with whatever it was built to do. That gap between noticing and caring is the whole question.

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I recently walked into a fast food restaurant for the first time in years. Ordering happened on tablets. Pickup happened at a small counter where someone called out a number. It was a room of tables and chairs with no vibe and no welcome, a complete disconnect from what people do best: a warm smile, a follow-up question, even a short greeting. It felt like a waiting room. I am open to speeding things up, but eating and service have always gone hand in hand, and here the service had become a transaction.

I believe automated ordering plants a quiet sense of abandonment before the guest ever realizes it. They are paying for a service, and the first thing they meet is a screen. A person who returns to the same table and the same server is greeted, drawn into small talk, and remembered, because it is in their nature to do so. A machine remembers only what it was programmed to remember. Familiarity is what brings people back, and no system delivers it.

The same logic is moving into hotels. The agents at the front desk are busy, so we add an AI agent to answer everything. Now imagine that at a five-star property. It does not happen there, because those properties were founded on providing, caring and delivering outstanding guest experiences, and those require people. So why is it acceptable anywhere else, when a person's perception, psychology and feelings are best reached by another person?

People can read a room. We notice a tightened jaw, a tired smile, a guest who wants conversation and a guest who wants to be left alone, and we adjust in seconds. That is non-verbal communication, and it is how one person can change another's mood without a single scripted line. Empathy, sincerity and genuine care are not features we have learned to deliver. They are what happens when one human understands another. A menu that says press 1 for this and press 2 for that cannot do it, because it was built to process a request, not to notice a person.

Look at where the affluent end of the industry is heading. One of the biggest shifts is the privatization of the dining experience: deeply bespoke, delivered entirely by people, sometimes with phones frowned upon. Every part of it is carried out by humans, and the automated behaviors come from the habits we recognize as the highest standards of service. I doubt that experience could be unique if a robot delivered it. So why is automating every system becoming the growing consensus, when what many operations need is a more structured approach to improving the experience?

Some fields have earned their acceleration. Healthcare, space, environmental sustainability, development and the arts rest on years of accumulated research, and serious combined brainpower applied to that foundation can move humanity forward. Other fields, hospitality among them, exist to meet a person in the moment, where the response itself is the product. The same tool does not mean the same thing in both places.

Some things were never meant to be optimized. Knowledge passed from one generation to the next. Tradition. Legacy. Trust built slowly, between people, over time. We made it this far without this disruptor, and we did it in an organic way. Now many of us are willing to hand it all to a system that waits for us to supply the initiative before it gives us an answer. That is not a small trade, and it deserves more than a rush.

I am not against development and growth. I am for being deliberate about it. The question in front of every leader is not whether to automate. It is where we automate, why we do it, and how purposeful it is to the experience we are delivering.